

THE SOMATIC RESET SERIES

The ADHD Nervous System

A Somatic Approach to Focus and Calm

Disclaimer

This book is intended for educational and informational purposes only. It is not a substitute for professional medical, psychological, or psychiatric advice, diagnosis, or treatment. Always consult a qualified healthcare provider before making changes to your health routine, especially if you have a pre-existing condition.

The practices described here are general wellness approaches. Results will vary between individuals. The author and publisher accept no liability for outcomes arising from use of this material.

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ADHD Is a Nervous System Difference

ADHD is not a deficit of attention. It's a difference in how the nervous system regulates attention, motivation, emotion, and activation. Understanding it this way — as a fundamentally different regulatory system rather than a broken version of a neurotypical one — changes everything about how you work with it.

The ADHD Nervous System in Plain Language

The ADHD nervous system is interest-based, not importance-based. Neurotypical nervous systems can activate for tasks based on perceived importance, obligation, or deadline — even when those tasks are not interesting. The ADHD nervous system activates most reliably for tasks that are interesting, urgent, novel, or personally meaningful. Everything else is a struggle — not because of laziness or poor character, but because of a difference in the dopamine-driven motivation circuitry.

Dr Edward Hallowell and Dr John Ratey, two of the most respected ADHD researchers and clinicians, describe the ADHD nervous system as inconsistent rather than deficient. It's not that focus is always unavailable — many people with ADHD have hyperfocus states where they can concentrate for hours on something genuinely engaging. The problem is control: the inability to reliably direct focus, rather than the absence of focus itself.

Emotionally, the ADHD nervous system is more reactive than neurotypical ones. Rejection sensitive dysphoria (RSD), described by William Dodson, is the experience of intense emotional pain triggered by perceived criticism or rejection. For many people with ADHD, this is actually the most impairing aspect of the condition — more than the focus difficulties.

The Dysregulated ADHD Nervous System

Without appropriate support, the ADHD nervous system tends toward two poles: under-activated (bored, flat, unable to start) and over-activated (overwhelmed, flooded, unable to stop). The transitions between these states, and the time spent at the extremes, produce enormous nervous system strain over time.

Many adults with ADHD — particularly those who were never diagnosed or who relied on coping mechanisms —

arrive at midlife with nervous systems that are simultaneously depleted and dysregulated. The chronic effort of managing a system that works differently from the expected norm, in environments designed for neurotypical regulation, creates a specific kind of burnout that standard burnout literature doesn't quite capture.

"The ADHD nervous system is not broken. It's a Ferrari engine in a body that was handed sedan instructions."

Somatic Regulation for ADHD

The body is one of the most accessible regulation tools for the ADHD nervous system — and one of the most underutilised.

Movement as Regulation, Not Reward

Exercise is one of the most evidence-supported interventions for ADHD. John Ratey's research has shown that aerobic exercise produces dopamine, norepinephrine, and serotonin increases that are functionally similar to the effect of stimulant medication — without the side effects, and with additional benefits for neuroplasticity.

For the ADHD nervous system, movement is not a reward for completing tasks. It's a regulatory input that makes task completion possible. Scheduling movement before demanding cognitive work — rather than after — is a practical application of this: fifteen to twenty minutes of aerobic activity before a period of focused work consistently improves executive function in ADHD.

Fidgeting as a Regulation Tool

Fidgeting has historically been treated as a symptom to suppress. Research by Dustin Sarver and others has challenged this: fidgeting in children with ADHD is associated with better working memory performance on difficult tasks. The physical movement activates the nervous system sufficiently to improve cognitive performance.

Practical application: have a designated fidget tool for focused work — a stress ball, a spinner ring, textured surfaces. Stand while working if possible. Pace during phone calls. Allow the physical movement that the nervous system is requesting rather than trying to suppress it.

Breathwork for ADHD Transitions

Transitions are among the most difficult moments for ADHD nervous systems — ending one activity and beginning another, shifting cognitive modes, moving between environments. The executive function required for smooth transitions is exactly what ADHD impairs.

A brief breathwork practice at transition points creates a physiological pause that supports the executive function shift: three physiological sighs before switching tasks, box breathing for two minutes before starting a difficult project, or a brief body scan when arriving home from work. These thirty-second to two-minute practices

function as transition bridges — they interrupt the momentum of one state and create space to enter the next.

"For the ADHD nervous system, the body is often the most direct path to the mind."

Working With the Interest-Based System

Fighting the interest-based ADHD nervous system is exhausting and largely ineffective. Working with it is faster and less demoralising.

Body Doubling and Co-Regulation

Body doubling — the practice of working in the presence of another person, even without interaction — is one of the most widely used ADHD regulation strategies and one of the least scientifically studied despite overwhelming anecdotal support. The presence of another person activates the social engagement system (ventral vagal), which appears to support executive function and reduce the nervous system dysregulation that makes starting difficult.

This is why ADHD people often work better in coffee shops, co-working spaces, or on video calls with a friend. The social regulatory input from another nervous system stabilises the ADHD one sufficiently to make initiation possible.

Sensory Environments for ADHD Focus

The ADHD nervous system responds strongly to sensory environment. The right sensory input can be regulatory; the wrong kind can tip the system into overwhelm or boredom. Finding your specific sensory profile — whether you work better with background music or silence, warm or cool environments, dimmer or brighter light, more or less physical movement — is a practical regulation tool.

Many people with ADHD work well with music that has a consistent beat and no lyrics (film scores, electronic, classical) because it provides a steady rhythmic input that keeps the nervous system from seeking stimulation elsewhere. Others need silence. There's no universal answer — the answer is your answer, found through deliberate experimentation.

"The ADHD nervous system will always seek interest. Your job is to become the architect of that interest, not its victim."

Managing the Emotional Intensity

The emotional dimension of ADHD is, for many people, the hardest part.

Rejection Sensitive Dysphoria

RSD produces sudden, intense emotional pain in response to perceived criticism, rejection, or failure. The operative word is perceived — the triggering event does not need to be objectively rejecting. A neutral tone in an email, an unreturned call, an unintentional slight — these can produce emotional responses that are disproportionate in intensity and genuinely debilitating.

Somatic tools for RSD: when the emotional intensity arrives, ground immediately — feet on floor, physiological sigh, cold water on face if available. This is not suppression. It's reducing the acute intensity enough to allow choice. The emotion is real and valid. The goal is to give the prefrontal cortex a chance to come online before responding.

After the Storm

ADHD emotional responses typically resolve as quickly as they arrive — another distinguishing feature from mood disorders, where the states are more sustained. After an intense emotional episode, the nervous system needs recovery time and physical reset: movement, warmth, water, and time to settle before re-engaging with the triggering situation.

Building in explicit recovery time after emotional intensity — not pushing immediately back into productivity — is not weakness. It's how the ADHD nervous system functions. Honour the recovery time and you spend less total time in the cycle.

"You are not too sensitive. You have a nervous system that feels everything at full volume. That's different."
